

FTII, PUNE

CINEMA INC

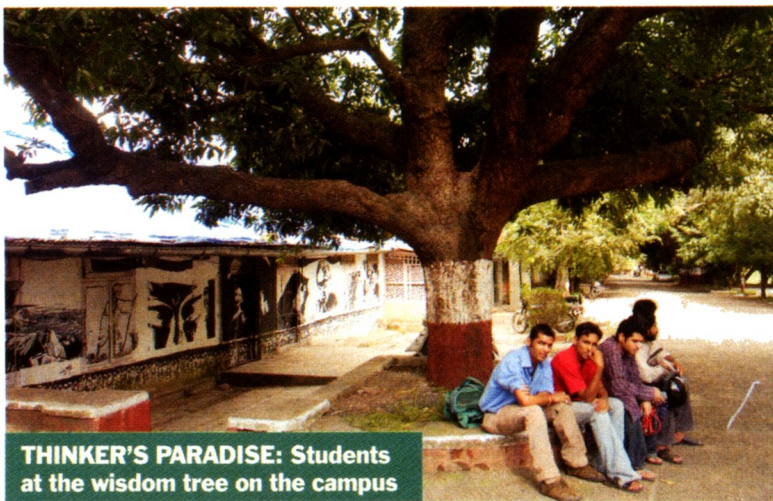
TROUBLE AGAIN The controversial acting course at the institute was revived in 2003, after a gap of 27 years since the National School of Drama was running a parallel course in Delhi.

I entered the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) on one strike and exited on another. Since it was set up in 1960, it's the strikes that have made the headlines. But at least it shows it's alive. The tragedy is: there is an incredible conspiracy of silence about the quality of education in our country. We are producing robots. In FTII, everyone was, and is, allowed to plough his own furrow and tread his own path. It was a place where we suddenly grew up. We had fantastic teach-

ers—there was the great Satish Bahadur; the master filmmaker Ritwik Ghatak would sometimes take a class. It was a place where individualism was encouraged, ironic given it is a state-run school. Take my batch. There were directors Vidhu Vinod Chopra, Kundan Shah, and cameraman Binod Pradhan. We would have massive fights about everything. All of us had come to the institute with incredible dreams. I had come after six-and-half-years in advertising, Vinod had come straight from Srinagar. We were a self-contained bunch, sharing our common passions of music, painting and, of course, films. It's a pity FTII doesn't get adequate government funds because it continues to produce filmmakers who are fundamentally iconoclast. All the work done here is original—no matter it may be terrible, reasonably good or even brilliant. I have kept my ties with the institute. I take a workshop there every two years and every time I return to see the work of the students, I feel like saying God bless them all. Because being from the FTII is like carrying the mark of Cain on your forehead. You are forever branded as someone who doesn't toe the line.

by Saeed Akhtar Mirza

The author is a 1976 batch FTII graduate



BHASKAR PAUL

MEDIA

FREE SPIRITS

It's a bright shining world, growing at a gleaming annual rate of 18 per cent, according to PricewaterhouseCoopers. But the Indian media and entertainment industry hides another truth. That of how inadequate it is in catering to the nation's vast population. According to the National Readership Survey, it has 222 million readers, though 292 million more can read but don't. Television reaches 112 million homes, which is almost the same as in the US but only half the total number in India. Radio reaches 27 per cent of the adult population and 13 million people access the Internet. Yet the independent spirit of its

media, sometimes chaotically so, educates as much as it entertains. Media consumption is fluctuating, with an urban Indian adult spending 39 minutes a day reading newspapers and magazines and an hour and 42 minutes watching television. From sting operations that catch public officials engaged in uncivil acts to scandalous news about starlets, its 350 channels, almost 52,000 newspapers and periodicals (India is the world's second largest market for newspapers) and over 200 private radio stations, apart from All India Radio, don't miss a trick.

by Kaveree Bamzai

NO DIVIDE Urban and rural India have almost the same numbers of readers: 112 million and 110 million respectively.

